CHAPTER 3

KINSHIP CASTE AND CLASS

CHAPTER ESSENCE AT A GLANCE:
Master social history from c. 600 BCE to 600 CE using the Mahabharata: patriliny, marriage rules (endogamy or exogamy), the Varna and Jati system, gotra rules, and marginalized groups (Chandalas).

4 CORE PRINCIPLES TO UNDERSTAND FIRST

• **The Critical Edition of the Mahabharata:** Monumental historical project initiated in 1919 by V.S. Sukthankar; compared thousands of Sanskrit manuscripts from across India to reconstruct a 13,000-page critical text.

• **Patriliny and Marriage Prescriptions:** Society prioritized patriliny (tracing descent from father to son); Dharmasutras prescribed eight forms of marriage, mandating kanyadana and exogamy (marrying outside one's gotra).

• **Varna Order and Social Mobility:** Brahmanical hierarchy divided society into four Varnas based on birth (Brahmanas, Kshatriyas, Vaishyas, Shudras); occupational sub-castes (Jatis) accommodated social mobility and craft guilds (Shrenis).

• **Untouchability and the Chandalas:** Manusmriti marginalized certain occupational groups as impure 'untouchables'; Chandalas handled corpses, lived outside villages, used discarded clothes, and struck wood clappers when entering towns.

ESSENTIAL HISTORICAL CHRONOLOGIES & THEMES

$$\text{Kinship Descent} \iff \text{Patriliny (Father to Son)} \quad [\text{Exceptions: Satavahanas Matronymics}]$$

Dominant Lineage Transmission Rule in Ancient India

$$\text{Brahmanical Gotra Rules} \to \{\text{Exogamy: Marry Outside Gotra}, \quad \text{Women Adopt Husband's Gotra}\}$$

Two Invariable Gotra Marriage Dictums

$$\text{Varna Stratification} \iff \text{Brahmana} \succ \text{Kshatriya} \succ \text{Vaishya} \succ \text{Shudra}$$

Fourfold Divine Occupational Social Order

$$\text{Sukthankar Critical Edition (1919)} \iff 47\ \text{Years} \to 13{,}000\ \text{Pages} \to \text{Common Manuscript Kernel}$$

Scientific Textual Reconstitution of the Mahabharata

CRUCIAL EXAM PRECAUTIONS & VALUATION RUBRIC SECRETS

• **Alert:** Satavahana kings were known by matronymics (names derived from their mother, e.g. Gotamiputa Satakani), yet succession to the Satavahana throne was strictly PATRILINEAL.

• **Alert:** Varna was fixed at four by birth in Brahmanical theory; Jati had no fixed number and accommodated hundreds of occupational groups, tribal communities, and craft guilds.

• **Alert:** Endogamy refers to marriage within one's own kin group or caste; Exogamy refers to marriage outside one's kin group or gotra.

HIGH-YIELD CENTUM QUESTIONS & STEP-BY-STEP EXPLANATIONS

1. Explain the monumental project of preparing the Critical Edition of the Mahabharata led by V.S. Sukthankar. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Leadership and Scope:** Initiated in 1919 under the leadership of noted Sanskritist V.S. Sukthankar with a team of scholars over 47 years. **[1 Mark]**

• **Methodology:** Collected thousands of Mahabharata manuscripts written in diverse Indian scripts (Malayalam, Grantha, Devanagari, Bengali) from across the country. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Collation and Selection:** Selected only verses that appeared common to all manuscripts, publishing a 13,000-page critical edition with extensive footnotes recording regional variations. **[1.5 Marks]**

2. What were the two important Brahmanical rules concerning Gotras? State one historical exception. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Rule 1:** Women were expected to give up their father's gotra and adopt that of their husband upon marriage. **[1 Mark]**

• **Rule 2:** Members of the same gotra could not marry (mandatory gotra exogamy). **[1 Mark]**

• **Historical Exception:** Satavahana queens retained their fathers' gotras (Gotami, Vasithi) after marriage, and frequently practiced kin-group endogamy (cross-cousin marriage). **[1 Mark]**

3. Distinguish between Varna and Jati in ancient Indian society. [Score: 3 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Number:** Varna was fixed strictly at four (Brahmanas, Kshatriyas, Vaishyas, Shudras); Jatis had no fixed number and numbered into thousands. **[1.5 Marks]**

• **Nature and Accommodation:** Varna was an idealized theological hierarchy; Jati represented real occupational guilds (weavers, goldsmiths) and absorbed diverse tribal communities (Nishadas). **[1.5 Marks]**

4. Describe the social condition and obligations imposed on Chandalas according to the Manusmriti. [Score: 4 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Social Ostracization:** Placed at the very bottom of the social hierarchy; their touch and sight were considered polluting by the upper castes. **[1 Mark]**

• **Prescribed Duties:** Obliged to dispose of corpses of people who had no relatives and serve as executioners. **[1 Mark]**

• **Living Conditions:** Forced to live outside village settlements, use discarded broken clay pots, wear clothes of the dead, and wear iron ornaments. **[1 Mark]**

• **Town Restrictions:** Chinese pilgrim Faxian noted that Chandalas had to sound a wooden clapper when entering towns so people could avoid seeing them. **[1 Mark]**

5. Define Patriliny. Why did families value sons in early Indian society? [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Definition:** Tracing descent and inheritance through the male line from father to son, grandson, and so on. **[1 Mark]**

• **Valuation of Sons:** Sons were essential to continue the lineage, perform funerary rites, and inherit ancestral property; daughters had no claims on ancestral land. **[1 Mark]**

6. Give two historical examples to show that anyone who had resources and power could become a king, regardless of Kshatriya birth. [Score: 2 Marks]

Answer & Key Valuation Steps:

• **Example 1:** The Shungas and Kanvas, successors of the Mauryas, were Brahmanas by birth. **[1 Mark]**

• **Example 2:** The Shakas from Central Asia were considered 'mlechchhas' (barbarians), yet ruled extensively in western India. **[1 Mark]**